The Script of a Life: The K-Pop Industry

The connections people feel with celebrities, with artists and influencers are very real. But what if the very thing they love is simply a persona—a facade?

If you've read "The Last Answer" by Isaac Asimov, you'll know what I'm talking about.
Asimov, who was considered the king, perhaps even the godfather of science fiction, first published this short story in the January 1980 issue of *Analog Science Fiction and Fact.*

Forty-five-year-old physicist Murray Templeton dies in his lab due to a heart attack and wakes up in a daze, noticing that he was watching the scene in the lab from above. His vision starts fading as darkness consumes him, and he sees a vague human figure in the last glimmer of light.

The Voice reconstructs him and brings him back to life as a source of His entertainment in a universe entirely under His control. Murray's purpose? It's to think. To think for eternities and discover new knowledge. The Voice constructed this universe, life, and minds because He wants a surprise—something random, something erratic.

The trap? Murray cannot destroy himself, as the Voice will simply adjust the nexus, remove the option that finished him, and bring him back.

"The Last Answer" not only predicted the modern world, but specifically the entertainment industry. The similarities between the story and the entertainment industry can only be viewed if looked at the broader picture. Murray Templeton is a victim. His ending was stolen from him for the sake of entertainment. He has no freedom except for what the Voice allows him. No choice, no decisions. He's merely a puppet—a mere pawn in the Voice's cruel game.

Now, look at the artists of the entertainment industry. It has been proven countless times how cruel the show business is, how inhumanely the companies treat their artists. If an artist does something wrong, people jump to hate. Yet the companies are the ones controlling every decision. Every single move is pre-planned. The companies are brilliant masterminds. They found the perfect path to limitless money.

I would like to turn to the K-Pop Industry to show evidence. It's all a game of psychology. From my perspective though, it's even worse for Korean artists because, unlike the Western industry, they're called *idols*. They're quite effectively manufactured to be worshipped—to be idolised.

Furthermore, not only is sexualization very common in this industry, but the sexualization of minors is through the roof here. Female groups with minors are often given clothes without

proper coverage, provocative choreographies, and lyrics with clear sexual innuendo. 5th gen group BABYMONSTER's company, YG, has faced scrutiny many times due to the nature of some choreographies with minors Rora and Chiquita, alongside the group's performance outfits, which managed to bring a massive wave of criticism towards their stylists. 4th gen group NewJeans' company ADOR faced intense backlash back in August 2022 due to the sexual nature of the lyrics from the song 'Cookie.' At the time, the youngest member, Hyein, was 14. Other members–Haerin was 16, and Danielle and Hanni were 17, leaving only Minji to be an adult. Even then, she was just 18.

Not only do companies not protect minors, but they also actively sexualise them to bring in more fans.

The companies also very clearly push parasocialism to generate more revenue. The most widely known group, BTS, is going into their 30s, yet they cannot admit they have had partners, as it would cause millions of damage in stock due to the nature of their relationships with their fandom, ARMY.

Even Stray Kids, a group known for its authenticity and creative freedom, falls into this category. The artists cannot be blamed either because they're victims too. They're more of a victim than the fans are. Most people decide to become trainees in their early teenage years, around 13, with some even making it as early as 8-10. They don't understand the industry, the issues. Neither do their parents. Their parents think they're sending their kids off to somewhere safe and nurturing, but it's the complete opposite. Every little movement, every line, every outfit is controlled by the companies.

Murray is the puppet in the story, and The Voice is the puppeteer—the mastermind. The Voice is the employers, the money-hungry companies. The artists don't have any control over their lives when they sign the contracts. They essentially sell their souls.

In the end, idols are just slaves of an industry that preys upon innocent children.

Companies pre-plan everything. Before debut, the members are presumably evaluated, and their personalities are amped up to 100 to get maximum attention from fans. Members like Chan, Hyunjin, and Felix get the most focus because they're openly affectionate towards fans, meaning they generate more attention. More attention means more interest; fans will buy more of their merch as they feel validated, hence more attention means more revenue for the company.

This brings me to a theory I have regarding Lee Know. He is my bias, and he's been my role model since I was 11. Throughout my time in the fandom, I've consistently seen him get ignored by the company. So my question is—

What if the company ignores him due to his flawless professionalism?

Lee Know, whose birth name is Lee Minho, is the perfect employee. He keeps his head down and treats being a K-Pop Idol strictly as a 9-5 job. He has strict boundaries to protect his mental health, because that is the only aspect of his life that is in his control. Everything else has already been curated to fit the image the company chooses for him. Due to his bluntness and refusal to put up an act (except for what is generally needed), many fans find him rude at first glance. Even when he really isn't.

So what if the company intentionally ignores him because he refuses to do anything more than absolutely needed, as specified in the contract? He does not do fan-service. So the company keeps the focus on the more loving guys like Chan, Hyunjin, and Felix. Members who will keep the parasocialism alive.

I am not saying they do not speak out; they do. Chan leads STAYVille (STAY=Fandom Name) like a military. If he sees something is wrong, he speaks up and scolds fans on the paid chat service, JYPE Bubble. But that does not mean they do not generate “boyfriend content” to create unhealthy relationships. Which, furthermore, fuels an obsession. Obsession means parasocialism. And, going back to my previous point, parasocialism means more revenue.

However, Lee Know has definitely built his loyal fandom due to his blunt honesty and “4D personality” (quirkiness). He is adored due to his catlike mannerisms and feline beauty. Aside from that, he is a philanthropist, known for actively sponsoring children domestically and internationally through the World Vision Project and donating to cat shelters and hospitals. Lee Know was officially named the youngest member of World Vision’s esteemed “Bob Pierce Honor Club” on February 28, 2024.

Lee Know immediately contributed to emergency relief efforts following the devastating Turkey-Syria earthquake in February 2023. Though this is less well-known, Lee Know also participated in the 18th "Love Your W" Breast Cancer Awareness Campaign, alongside member Felix, starring in digital promotional videos holding the iconic "Love Your W" charity art mugs.

Lee Know has also worn accessories to spread awareness. He has been spotted wearing an earring of a polar bear from the Tear of Glacier collection from the Korean jewelry brand Wing Bling multiple times. A percentage of every purchase is donated to the World Wide Fund for Nature, which supports the conservation of endangered species. He has also worn another earring that supports the conservation of snow leopards from the same brand. He has mentioned the cause in live broadcasts.

In August 2019, Lee Know famously engaged fans through the official Stray Kids Twitter account, sharing a photo to ask for their input on which earrings he should wear for the day, showing a safety-pin earring, alongside his snow leopard and polar bear earrings. Safety-pin accessories have a specific meaning: “You’re safe with me,” primarily symbolizing solidarity and signaling that you stand with minorities such as people of color, immigrants, religious minorities, the LGBTQ+ community, the general population of women, and vulnerable individuals.

Furthermore, fans feel fondness for him due to his positive mindset. Lee Know promotes balanced, normal eating habits over restrictive idol dieting, emphasizing strength over body aesthetics. He is also known for giving fans random yet comforting advice and texts, the best known one being a Bubble message where he says, “You did well, you did well. Even if you just breathed, you did well.”

This proves that human connection can still be generated through strict corporate restraints.

The corporate neglect contrasts sharply against Lee Know’s genuinely kind nature, causing more fans to notice it. He has gotten reused clothes many times; he has been given almost identical black leather jackets for every comeback, and once he was left without proper security in the airport, allowing fans to crowd him. Multiple times, staff members have made fun of his weight, calling him “Chubby cat,” when he clearly showed discomfort.

He has constantly been given outfits that are uncomfortable for him to perform in. As one of the main dancers of Stray Kids, Lee Know prefers comfortable clothes in which he can give the maximum amount of energy to dance in front of his fans. He has also stated he prefers not to show a lot of skin, yet there has been a pattern of stylists giving him showy shirts.

At the Governor’s Ball this year, Stray Kids took the stage as headliners. In the 90-degree heat, Lee Know was given black leather pants. Leather provides high thermal insulation, trapping body heat, and as it sticks to bare skin, it has poor breathability. The color black absorbs heat. Lee Know was seen pouring water on his thighs, presumably because he was experiencing heat exhaustion and burning up.

The only positive outcome that has come out of the negligence Lee Know faces is that he has avoided fueling parasocialism that is seen in so many other groups.

Even now, Lee Know remains a servant to a flawed, inhumane system that has lived for decades without issues. A mere puppet that will be discarded as soon as he’s out of use.

Only now, the cracks are starting to show.

And fans are finding out.